

LEVEL 1 • BEGINNER

Prompt Engineering: From Asking to Composing

Stop getting vague answers. Learn one structure that turns any request into a strong prompt — and refine it in seconds.



YOUR LEARNING JOURNEY

From asking to designing — what each level of the program builds

YOU ARE HERE

1

STAGE 1

Asking

One-line requests, hit or miss. The everyday habit this program upgrades.

2

STAGE 2 · TODAY

Composing

CO-STAR to build strong prompts on purpose — then the Refine loop to improve them in one follow-up.

3

STAGE 3 · INTERMEDIATE

Directing

Show it examples, ask it to reason first, structure long prompts, and ground answers in your own BJ's documents.

4

STAGE 4 · ADVANCED

Designing

Chain tasks into steps, build reusable team templates, engineer context, and evaluate outputs with guardrails.



WHERE ARE YOU NOW?

Sound familiar? Then you're in the right room.



“I type one line and hope.”

The most common habit — and the easiest to beat.



“My results are hit-or-miss.”

Good prompts make results repeatable.



“I restart when it's wrong.”

There's a faster way: refine.



“I've no repeatable structure.”

By the end, you'll have one: CO-STAR.



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this module, you will be able to:

1

Explain what AI is really doing

Why a clear prompt beats a one-liner.

2

Build a prompt with CO-STAR

The six parts of a strong prompt.

3

Steer tone, length, and format

So the answer fits your reader.

4

Refine instead of restarting

Lift a result with one follow-up.



WHY THIS MATTERS

Better prompts, better answers — every time

You've all tried prompting. The gap between a frustrating answer and a great one is rarely the tool — it's the prompt. Today we make that gap deliberate, with one structure you can reuse and teach to anyone on your team.

OUR RUNNING EXAMPLE TODAY

A member emailed, upset:

"BJ's charged me \$60 to auto-renew. Nobody warned me. I want my money back."

You need to write the reply.



THE MENTAL MODEL

A capable assistant — not a mind-reader, not a search box

It isn't reading your mind, and it isn't looking things up on the web. It works from what you give it plus what it already knows. So a one-line request leaves it guessing — at your situation, your policy, and how you want to sound. Give it those, and it can genuinely help.

WHAT A ONE-LINER LEAVES TO GUESS

“reply to this angry member”

- Who are you?
- What's the policy?
- What tone?
- How long?
- What outcome?



LIVE DEMO · BEFORE

The one-line prompt

▶ PASTE THIS INTO CLAUDE

Write a reply to this member:

"BJ's charged me \$60 to auto-renew my membership. Nobody warned me. I want my money back."

WHAT CLAUDE GIVES BACK

Dear Valued Member,

Thank you for reaching out. We're sorry to hear about your frustration. Your membership was renewed in accordance with our standard terms and conditions.

If you have any further questions, please don't hesitate to contact us.

Best regards,
BJ's Wholesale Club

→ ***Cold and generic. Explains nothing, offers no options, and quietly refuses the refund.***



THE FRAMEWORK

CO-STAR: the six parts of a strong prompt



C — Context

Who you are and the situation.



O — Objective

What you want it to do.



S — Style

How it should read — format, length.



T — Tone

The voice: warm, formal, upbeat.



A — Audience

Who the answer is for.



R — Response

The exact output shape you want.



SPECIFIC BEATS VAGUE

The same six parts, filled in for one member complaint



C — Context

✗ *"I work in customer service"*

✓ I'm in Member Care at BJ's; a \$60 auto-renewal caught a member off guard.



O — Objective

✗ *"help with this complaint"*

✓ Acknowledge the frustration, explain the reminder, lay out their options.



S — Style

✗ *"make it sound professional"*

✓ Plain language, short paragraphs, no jargon.



T — Tone

✗ *"be nice about it"*

✓ Warm and empathetic — never defensive.



A — Audience

✗ *"a customer"*

✓ A member who feels blindsided and wants their money back.



R — Response

✗ *"write an email"*

✓ A 120-150 word email that ends with a clear next step.



LIVE DEMO · AFTER

The same request, built with CO-STAR

▶ PASTE THIS INTO CLAUDE

Context: I'm in Member Care at BJ's. A member is upset their membership auto-renewed — a \$60 charge they say they weren't warned about. Policy: full refund within 30 days if unused; a renewal reminder goes out ~30 days before.

Objective: Reply that acknowledges the frustration, gently explains the reminder, and lays out their options.

Style: Plain language, short paragraphs, no jargon.

Tone: Warm, empathetic — never defensive.

Audience: A frustrated member who feels blindsided.

Response: A 120–150 word email — acknowledge, give the two options, end with a clear next step and warm sign-off.

WHAT CLAUDE GIVES BACK

Hi [Name],

I'm sorry — an unexpected \$60 charge is frustrating, and I understand why you're upset.

Memberships renew automatically, and we email a reminder ~30 days ahead, which may have been missed.

Two options: if you haven't used your membership since it renewed, I can refund the full \$60. Or if you'd like to keep it, I'll show the savings ahead this year.

Reply with your choice and I'll take care of it right away.

Warmly, [Your name] — BJ's Member Care

→ ***Specific, warm, and it solves the problem — real options and a clear next step.***



THE PAYOFF

One line vs. CO-STAR

ONE-LINE PROMPT

"Write a reply to this member..."

WHAT YOU GET

A cold, generic apology that explains nothing and offers no options.

Fast to type — slow to fix.

CO-STAR PROMPT

Context · Objective · Style · Tone · Audience · Response

WHAT YOU GET

A warm reply that acknowledges the issue, explains the reminder, and gives two clear options + a next step.

A minute more — and actually usable.



THE REFINE LOOP

A strong prompt is a first draft — then refine

You rarely nail it in one shot, and you don't need to. Read what came back, decide what's off, and ask for a change in plain words. Refining keeps everything good and fixes only what's missing — far faster than starting over.

REFINE, DON'T RESTART

"Make it warmer."

"Keep it under 120 words."

"Offer a \$20 courtesy credit."

Small nudges → big improvement.



LIVE DEMO · REFINE

Improve it in one follow-up

▶ PASTE THIS INTO CLAUDE

Make it a little warmer, keep it under 120 words, and offer a one-time \$20 courtesy credit if they'd like to stay.

WHAT CLAUDE GIVES BACK

Hi [Name],

I'm so sorry for the surprise — a \$60 charge you weren't expecting is genuinely frustrating.

Here's what I can do: if your membership is unused since renewing, I'll refund the full \$60. Or, if you'd like to stay, I'd love to add a one-time \$20 courtesy credit as a thank-you.

Just reply with what works best and I'll sort it out today.

Warmly, [Your name] — BJ's Member Care

→ ***One follow-up — not a restart. Warmer, shorter, and more generous.***



WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

You have met every goal we set at the start



Explain why structure matters

A capable assistant, not a mind-reader.



Build a prompt with CO-STAR

Six parts, every time.



Steer tone, length & format

The answer fits the reader.



Refine, not restart

One follow-up lifts the result.



KEEP-AT-YOUR-DESK CARD

Your CO-STAR + Refine cheat-sheet

C

Context Who you are and the situation.

O

Objective What you want it to do.

S

Style How it should read — format, length, structure.

T

Tone The voice — warm, formal, upbeat.

A

Audience Who the answer is for.

R

Response The exact output shape you want.

↻

Refine Check it, then improve in one follow-up — don't restart.



TRY THIS ON MONDAY

Pick one real task and CO-STAR it

Take a message you'd normally dash off, write it with all six parts, then refine once. Next stop on your journey: Directing (Intermediate) — examples, reasoning, and working from your own documents.



OPTIONAL — GO DEEPER

Appendix

Optional extras — a taste of what's next, and where to learn more.



OPTIONAL

A taste of what's next: show it an example

One of the most powerful moves is giving the AI a sample of what 'good' looks like, then asking for more in that style. You'll go deep on this in the Intermediate course — here's the idea.

THE IDEA

Paste an example you like →

“Now do the same for ____, in this style.”



EXAMPLE

Show, don't just tell

WEAK

"Write a description for our rotisserie chicken."

WHAT YOU GET

A generic blurb that could be any store's.

STRONG

"Here's a description we love: [paste]. Write one in the same style for our rotisserie chicken."

WHAT YOU GET

Copy that matches BJ's voice and format.



GO FURTHER

Where to learn more



Anthropic — Prompt engineering overview

The techniques, from the source.



GovTech — CO-STAR playbook

Where the framework comes from.



Google — Prompting Essentials

A free short course for everyone.



The Prompt Engineering Guide

promptingguide.ai — a deeper reference.